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Rashid Rover 2 to be launched in 2026

DUBAI
BY SAJILA SASEENDRAN
Chief Reporter

Shaikh Hamdan Bin Mohammed Bin Rashid Al Maktoum, Crown Prince of Dubai, Deputy Prime Minister, Minister of Defence, and Chairman of The Executive Council of Dubai, yesterday announced the launch of Rashid Rover 2, the UAE's second mission to the moon's surface, by an American company in 2026.

"I witnessed the signing of a strategic agreement between MBRSC and US-based Firefly Aerospace to provide the payload delivery services for the Rashid 2 Rover, as part of the Emirates Lunar Mission scheduled for 2026. The mission is set to make the UAE only the second country in history to attempt a landing in the moon's far side, placing the nation at the forefront of space exploration," Shaikh Hamdan posted on X. "Our objective is not only to reach new destinations in space, but to generate meaningful knowledge that contributes to humanity's understanding of the universe," he added.

Far side of the moon

Under the strategic agreement, the Rashid 2 Rover will be deployed to the far side of the moon on Firefly Aerospace's Blue Ghost lander stacked on the Elytra Dark orbital vehicle. The Rashid 2 Rover will join Blue Ghost Mission 2, in 2026, alongside payloads from Australia, the European Space Agency (ESA), and Nasa.

Bakery supplies reach Gaza as part of UAE's aid delivery

HUMANITARIAN CONVOY DELIVERS FLOUR SHIPMENTS TO RESTART BAKERIES

ABU DHABI

A humanitarian aid convoy arrived in the Gaza Strip under Operation Chivalrous Knight 3, supported by the International Charity Organisation, to urgently ease the population's growing hardship.

The convoy delivered flour shipments to restart bakeries that had ceased operations due to a shortage of essential supplies, in an effort to ease the worsening famine and humanitarian crisis.

This delivery is part of the ongoing relief efforts under Operation Chivalrous Knight 3 to address the crisis in the Gaza Strip, following the closure of border crossings for over two months, which halted relief operations and blocked the entry of basic goods, resulting in the shutdown of bakeries.

The convoy reflects the UAE's ongoing humanitarian commitment under Operation Chivalrous Knight 3, which aims to deliver urgent assistance amid the deepening crisis, with a focus on essential needs, particularly bread, a daily staple in critical shortage.

Aid groups collect deliveries

Aid groups have collected humanitarian aid carried by about 90 trucks, out of a total of nearly 200 that have entered Gaza since Israel began allowing limited goods in earlier this week, the United Nations said yesterday.

Jens Laerke, spokesperson for the UN humanitarian agency OCHA, said the trucks that entered carried medicine, wheat flour and nutrition supplies. Aid



AFF

■ Employees of a bakery in Deir Al Balah in the central Gaza Strip fill bags with freshly-baked bread after Israel allowed limited humanitarian aid to enter the Palestinian territory yesterday.

● This delivery is part of the ongoing relief efforts under Operation Chivalrous Knight 3 to address the crisis in the Gaza Strip, following the closure of border crossings for over two months.

groups faced significant challenges distributing the aid because of insecurity, the risk of looting and coordination issues with Israeli authorities, Laerke added.

Under international pressure, Israel has allowed dozens of aid trucks into Gaza after blocking all food, medicine, fuel and other material for nearly three months.

But the supplies have been sitting on the Gaza side of the Kerem Shalom crossing with Israel.

The Israeli army issued an evacuation warning yesterday for 14 neighbourhoods of northern Gaza, as it pressed a renewed offensive that has drawn international condemnation. Gaza's civil defence agency said Israeli

strikes had killed at least 52 people since dawn yesterday.

UAE condemns shooting

Meanwhile, the UAE strongly condemned the shooting incident that led to the killing of two employees at the Israeli embassy in Washington, denouncing the act as a grave criminal offence. The Ministry of Foreign Affairs extended its heartfelt condolences and expressed deep sympathy and solidarity with the families of the victims and the Israeli people in the wake of this heinous attack.

— Agencies

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Dubai Taxi Company joins forces with Bolt to add 6,000+ taxis to app-based fleet

DUBAI
BY ASHFAQ AHMED
Senior Assistant Editor

Passengers in Dubai can now get up to 30 per cent cashback when they hail a cab using the Bolt app.

Dubai Taxi Company (DTC) has expanded its strategic partnership with Bolt, the global ride-hailing platform, by integrating over 6,000 taxis into the Bolt app. This includes People of Determination Taxis and Ladies & Family (Pink) Taxis, making

80%

of taxi trips to be shifted to digital platforms in Dubai

inclusive and reliable transport more accessible than ever across the emirate.

Big discount

To celebrate this expansion, Bolt is offering 30 per cent cashback on users' first three taxi rides, with no surge pricing, a strong incentive as Dubai's demand for seamless, app-based transport continues to rise.

With the integration, resi-

dents and tourists alike can now book DTC taxis through the Bolt app. This will give passengers access to transparent pricing, accurate routing via Bolt's proprietary mapping system, and advanced in-app safety features such as emergency buttons, live tracking, and a driver rating system that promotes high service standards.

The initiative aligns with the Dubai Government's goal of transitioning 80 per cent of taxi trips to e-booking platforms, and forms a key part of DTC's 2025–2029 strategic roadmap.

That plan aims to solidify DTC's position as the largest taxi operator in the UAE and a digital transportation leader in the region's estimated Dh6 billion taxi and e-hailing market.

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